The world in brief

Catch up quickly on the global stories that matter

Photograph: AFP

The **Bangladesh Nationalist Party** won the country's first election since protesters toppled Sheikh Hasina, a despotic prime minister, in 2024. The party took 204 of 300 seats in parliament. Jamaat-e-Islami, an Islamist group, won 76. The BNP—led by Tarique Rahman, the scion of a famous political family—has vowed to fight graft and preserve freedom of speech.

Asian stocks fell following a sell-off in **American markets**. America's tech-heavy NASDAQ dropped by around 2%, while the S&P 500 slid by more than 1.5%. Gold also fell by more than 3% on Thursday before recouping some losses on Friday. Markets have been rattled in recent weeks by fears that artificial intelligence could disrupt a swathe of companies.

Goldman Sachs's top lawyer resigned over her association with Jeffrey Epstein. Kathryn Ruemmler's name came up in the more than 3m pages of documents recently released by America's Department of Justice relating to the dead sex offender. Epstein had offered to help secure contacts for Ms Ruemmler's private law practice. He also sent her expensive gifts. She said that by resigning she was putting "Goldman Sachs's interests first".

Donald Trump announced that he was repealing the Environmental Protection Agency's **"endangerment finding"**, a scientific judgment from 2009 stating that greenhouse-gas emissions pose a risk to public health. The ruling had allowed the government to regulate car emissions and require reporting on emissions standards. Mr Trump claimed that such policies raise vehicle prices. Environmentalists are expected to challenge the decision in court.

The president's "border czar", Tom Homan, said that federal immigration agents would end their operation in **Minnesota**. The arrival of nearly 3,000 agents in the state in December sparked widespread protests, which intensified after officers killed two American citizens. Mr Homan called the operation a "great success" in arresting "illegal aliens". American opinion has turned against the president's deportation campaign.

America and **Taiwan** signed a trade agreement, formalising a deal announced in January. America will reduce tariffs on Taiwan to 15%, the same rate that it applies to goods from Japan and South Korea. In return Taiwan will lower levies on America and buy billions-of-dollars-worth of its goods, including liquefied natural gas, crude oil and aircraft.

Britain's top civil servant, Sir Chris Wormald, was forced out by the Labour government after barely a year in the job, making him the shortest-serving cabinet secretary. Sir Keir Starmer, the prime minister, was said to be unhappy with Sir Chris's sluggish reform of the service. His departure marks the end of a dramatic week for the prime minister, who is barely clinging on to power.

Figure of the day: 1.4m, the number of Jeffrey Epstein-related emails processed by a group of software engineers for Jmail.world, a website. Read *The Economist*'s analysis of Epstein's network.

Photograph: Alamy

Europe takes stock of its security

On Friday political leaders and defence bigwigs gathered for the annual Munich Security Conference. Few observers expect an upheaval to match that at last year's event, when J.D. Vance, America's vice-president, shocked Europeans by lambasting their record on free speech and political freedom. This time Marco Rubio, the secretary of state, who holds more orthodox foreign-policy views, will lead the American delegation.

The meeting comes as a shake-up of NATO's military command structure is under way. This week the alliance announced that America would take over the bloc's maritime command, but hand over several other top posts to European countries. More changes are expected to follow. The alliance's defence ministers met in Brussels on Thursday. Europeans, reeling from Donald Trump's recent threats to take Greenland from a NATO member, were somewhat reassured by Elbridge Colby, the Pentagon's policy chief. He spoke, relatively conventionally, of a NATO based on "partnership rather than dependency", and urged Europeans to be "pragmatic".

Photograph: Getty Images

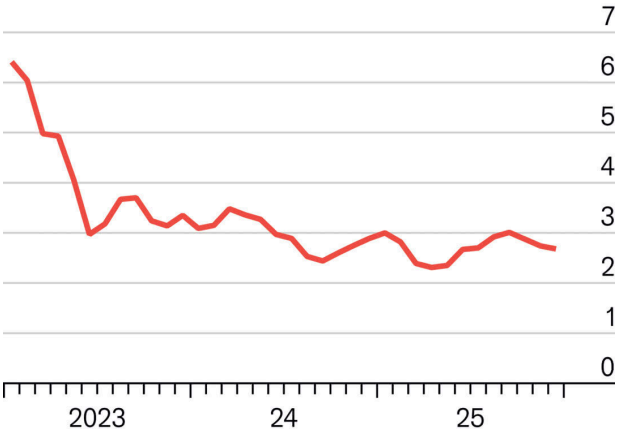
Some (possibly brief) respite from inflation in America

Before Donald Trump's tariffs, America had come tantalisingly close to vanquishing inflation. In April of last year annual inflation was 2.3%, just above the Federal Reserve's target of 2%. After that it shot up, reaching 3% in September, then dipped to 2.7%. This year it could finally decline to the Fed's target.

Tariff chaos has not, as feared, caused a destabilising spiral of worsening inflation expectations and rising prices. The jobs market, while solid, has weakened over the past year. Forecasters reckon that the next price figures, released on Friday, will be reassuring: they think inflation fell to 2.5% in January. Still, another Trumpian twist could be coming. The economy will soon feel the effects of the fiscal giveaways in the "Big, Beautiful" tax bill. Among them could be higher demand and prices.

Inflation frustration

United States, consumer prices,
% increase on a year earlier



Source: LSEG Workspace

Photograph: Getty Images

A dark moment for Japan's progressives

At a snap election on February 8th Japan's ruling centre-right Liberal Democratic Party, led by Takaichi Sanae, the country's first female prime minister, won its biggest victory in the post-war era.

The main centre-left opposition, the Centrist Reform Alliance, suffered a humiliating defeat, shrinking from 173 seats to 49 in the lower house. Online, the party had acquired the unflattering nickname "5G", a play on the Japanese word for "old man", *oji-san*, in reference to the fact that its leaders were men in their 60s and 70s. Several of these old men stepped aside after the defeat, and on Friday the CRA's lawmakers elected Ogawa Junya as their next leader. At a mere 54-years-old, he is a comparative whippersnapper.

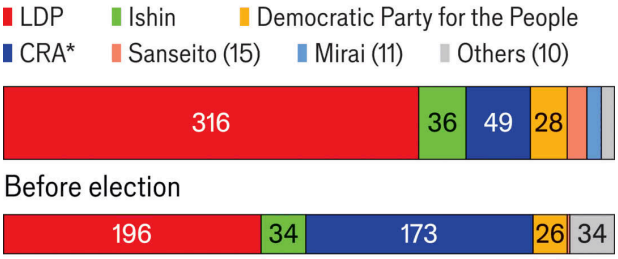
Mr Ogawa has promised to rebuild the party and fight for the liberal causes that Ms Takaichi spurns. The LDP's thumping mandate means that is likely to be an unrewarding pursuit.

Winning big

Japan, National Diet

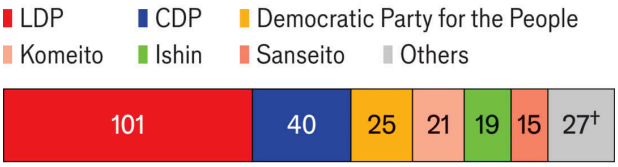
House of Representatives, elected Feb 8th 2026

Total seats=465



House of Councillors, elected Jul 20th 2025

Total seats=248



*Merger of CDP and Komeito †Includes one vacant seat

Sources: Japanese government; press reports

Photograph: Getty Images

The crackdown on dissent in America

Don Lemon will be arraigned in federal court in Minnesota on Friday. Last month the former CNN anchor, a frequent critic of President Donald Trump, covered a protest in St Paul, Minneapolis's neighbouring city, where activists stormed into a church during a service led by a pastor who was also a field director for Immigration and Customs Enforcement. According to the Department of Justice, this violated the congregation's civil rights.

The indictment, which also lays out charges against another journalist and seven protesters, accuses Mr Lemon of having "peppered [the pastor] with questions" in an "attempt to oppress and intimidate him". On Tuesday Mr Lemon said he would be represented by Joseph Thompson, until recently a leading prosecutor in the US attorney's office that is going after him. Mr Thompson is one of 14 prosecutors to have left the office this year in apparent protest. That leaves fewer to pursue the likes of Mr Lemon.

Photograph: Warner Bros. Pictures

Withering reviews for “Wuthering Heights”

Emerald Fennell’s adaptation of “Wuthering Heights” caused conniptions from the moment the project was announced in 2024. People objected to the fact that Australian actors, Margot Robbie and Jacob Elordi, would play Cathy and Heathcliff. After all, Emily Brontë’s novel is set in Yorkshire in the late 18th century. Many also thought that Heathcliff, described by Brontë as a “dark-skinned gypsy in aspect”, should have been played by a non-white actor. Some objected to the extravagant and defiantly anachronistic costumes.

Ms Fennell described writing the screenplay as an exercise in wish-fulfilment. She admits that she reshaped the plot and the characters in her screenplay; the result is an erotic fever dream, a bodice-ripper with a tragic ending. Some who don’t like that approach are reading “Wuthering Heights”, as one wrote online, “so that I can give the adapt[at]ion the hate it deserves”. It’s now showing in cinemas.

Illustration: Sandra Navarro

Daily quiz

We will serve you a new question each weekday. On Friday your challenge is to give us all five answers and tell us the theme. Email your responses (and your home city and country) by 1700 GMT on Friday to . We'll pick three winners at random and crown them on Saturday.

Friday: Which Manhattan venue is home to the New York Knicks?

Thursday: Who is currently fifth in line to the British throne?

I’ve liked lots of people ‘til I went on a picnic jaunt with them.

Bess Truman